



GOOD THINGS HAPPEN

Newsletter of Minnehaha United Methodist Church

We seek, we serve, we celebrate.

December

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Good Things Happen
is the newsletter of
Minnehaha United Methodist Church,
published each month.

**The deadline for January is
December 16**

Contributions may be brought to the
office or emailed to:
office@minnehaha.org
**3701 East 50th Street
Minneapolis, MN 55417**

About Us:

Minnehaha United Methodist Church is a thriving multi-generational, multicultural Christian community devoted to social justice and personal spiritual growth. The congregation is both mission- and worship-focused. In addition to its worship, education, and social activities, the church supports local mission activities, including a food shelf and a monthly food distribution program. The church also supports a variety of national and international relief, education, and development projects.

A Reconciling Congregation:

Minnehaha United Methodist Church opens our doors to all God's people. We will strive to offer unconditional love and acceptance to all persons, regardless of race, sexual orientation or faith history. We work to eliminate prejudice and discriminatory practices within ourselves and within our community. -adopted 2006

Our Mission:

We seek, we serve, we celebrate, we carry our Christian faith into our community and the world. We provide a caring gathering place to worship God and to grow spiritually. -reconfirmed 2011

December



SUNDAY WORSHIP

9:00 am Worship with organ and choir.

10:00 am Education and Fellowship

11:00 am Worship with band and vocals.

Infant and toddler care available all morning.

Minnehaha Happenings in December

Sun	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat
				1 World AIDS Day 9a Food Shelf Board 9a Fun & Fit 9a Minnehaha Play-date 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a We Make the Road by Walking 2:30p Brighter Minds Music	2 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a Al-Anon 6:30p RCA	3 8:45a Brighter Minds Music 9a UMW Cookie Bake
4 Communion 9a Worship with Organ & Choir 10a Education & Fellowship 11a Worship with Band 6p Youth /Conf. Classes 6:30p Togo Church 7p SAA 7p Venturing Crew	5 10a OA 1:30p Al-Anon 2p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Boy Scouts - Troop 1 6:30p Cub Scouts 6:30p Finance 6:30p UMW Leadership	6 9a Fun & Fit 10:30a Food Shelf 12p Music Lesson 1:30p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Toastmasters (Taleweavers)	7 10a Staff Meeting 4p Methodicals 6:45p Chancel Choir 7p Children's Council	8 9a Fun & Fit 9a Minnehaha Play-date 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a We Make the Road by Walking 1p Communion @ Nokomis Sq 2:30p Brighter Minds Music	9 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a Al-Anon 6:30p RCA 7p Blue Christmas Taizé 7p Fellowship Hall reserved	10 Human Rights Day 8:45a Brighter Minds Music
11 9a Worship with Organ & Choir 10a Education & Fellowship 11a Worship with Band 6p Youth Night (grades 6-12) 7p Pack 1 Plan 7p SAA	12 10a OA 1:30p Al-Anon 2p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Boy Scouts - Troop 1	13 9a Fun & Fit 10:30a Food Shelf 12p Music Lesson 1:30p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Church Council	14 Pageant rehearsal/dinner 10a UMW General Meeting Luncheon 4p Methodicals 6:45p Chancel Choir	15 9a Fun & Fit 9a Minnehaha Play-date 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a We Make the Road by Walking 2:30p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Trustees & B+G 6:30p UMW Simpson Meal Prep	16 Newsletter items due 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a Al-Anon 5:45p UMW Simpson Shelter 6:30p RCA	17 7a MinneHarvest 8:45a Brighter Minds Music
18 9a Worship with Organ & Choir 10a Education & Fellowship 11a Worship with Band 4p Christmas Pageant & Dinner 6:30p Togo Church 7p SAA 7p Venturing Crew	19 10a OA 1:30p Al-Anon 2p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Boy Scouts - Troop 1 6:30p Cub Scouts 6:30p Women's Soul Group	20 9a Fun & Fit 10:30a Food Shelf 12p Music Lesson 1:30p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Toastmasters (Taleweavers)	21 Winter Solstice 4p Methodicals 6:45p Chancel Choir	22 9a Fun & Fit 9a Minnehaha Play-date 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a We Make the Road by Walking 2:30p Brighter Minds Music	23 9a Newsletter Collation 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a Al-Anon 6:30p RCA	24 4p Christmas Eve Worship (Band) 10p Christmas Eve Worship (Organ & Candlelight)
25 Christmas 10a Christmas Day Worship 7p SAA	26 10a OA 1:30p Al-Anon 2p Brighter Minds Music 6:30p Boy Scouts - Troop 1	27 9a Fun & Fit 10:30a Food Shelf 12p Music Lesson 1:30p Brighter Minds Music 7p SPR	28 4p Methodicals 6:45p Chancel Choir	29 9a Fun & Fit 9a Minnehaha Play-date 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a We Make the Road by Walking 2:30p Brighter Minds Music	30 9:30a Brighter Minds Music 10a Al-Anon 6:30p RCA	31

Worship in December

Advent has begun, and we are painting pictures with visuals and words as we make our progression towards Christmas. The four Sundays prior to Christmas give us time to see how God's word still comes alive today. Since Christmas falls on a Sunday, we get the most days possible in Advent this year, so make the most of our time of spiritual preparation. Since Christmas falls on a Sunday, we'll have one service that day, at 10:00, singing Christmas carols and hearing the stories behind them. Christmas Eve will have our normal 4:00 service with music by The Methodicals and 10:00 service featuring the choir and organ. New Year's Day will also be a one-service Sunday at 10:00 with music by The Methodicals.

4th	"Seeing the Word: The Wolf Lies Down with the Lamb"	Isaiah 11:1-10
	<i>Communion</i>	
11th	"Seeing the Word: The Waters Break Forth"	Isaiah 35:1-10
18th	"Seeing the Word: A Young Woman Shall Give Birth"	Isaiah 7:10-16
24th	Christmas Eve Services at 4pm and 10pm	
25th	Christmas Sunday Service at 10am	

Future Events at Minnehaha UMC—Save the Date

- Jan. 1 – One service at 10:00
- Jan. 8 – United Methodist Women Sunday
- Jan. 11 – Food Shelf fundraising pasta dinner
- Jan. 22 – Infant Recognition
- Jan. 23 – New Monday evening Adult Study begins (on books that didn't make it into the New Testament)
- Jan. 26 – New Thursday morning Adult Study begins – same topic as Monday evening.
- Jan. 27-29 Winter Retreat at Camp Koronis
- Feb. 25 – My Changing Self workshop for children, youth, parents
- Feb. 26 – Camping Sunday
- Mar. 1 – Ash Wednesday (beginning of Lent)
- Mar. 4 – Auction
- Mar. 8 – Beginning of Lenten Study on prayer practices
- Mar. 12 – Daylight Savings begins (turn clocks ahead)

One-Service Sundays

Both Christmas and New Year's Day fall on Sundays this year, and we'll be having one worship service at 10:00 a.m. on both days. Christmas Day will feature the organ and Christmas hymns with the stories about their origin. New Year's Day will feature The Methodicals, we'll have communion, and will focus on making new decisions for a new year.

UMW Serving at Simpson Shelter

We will be serving at Simpson Shelter (31st. St. E. and 1st Ave. So.) on Friday, Dec. 16 starting at about 5:45 and finishing up around 8:00. If you would like to help out, please let Maureen Trepp know at 612-724-7620. There will be a car leaving church at 5:15 to carry over the food and, if you cannot make it to serve but would like to prep the food on Dec. 15, please let Maureen know. Thanks. (We can also bring youth to help serve or prep)

It's time for Advent.
Time to: Prepare. Focus. Hope. Love. Joy. Wonder. Breath.
It's time to prepare our hearts.
It's time to share the story & to share the light.



Join us as we begin the Advent season with an

Advent Wreath Making Party **EVERYONE is INVITED**

Minnehaha United Methodist Church
Sunday, November 27th
10am in the Fellowship Hall
Cost for each wreath: \$8



December Youth Events at Minnehaha UMC

Dec. 4

- Christmas Orchestra Rehearsal: 11:00 am with Jenny Ammerman. Please bring a music stand if you have one.
- Confirmation: Bible: Revelation. Classes are from 6:00– 7:30pm. Grades 6th-7th are with Lani in the 3rd floor Youth Room, 8th-9th Graders are with Becky in the Wesley Room, and 10th-12th Graders are with Kate in room 306.

Dec. 11

- Orchestra Rehearsal: 11am with Jenny Ammerman. Bring a music stand if you have one.
- Youth night: Lazer Tag at Zero Gravity! For grades 6th-12th. We will be leaving MUMC at 5:30pm and back around 8pm. Cost is \$15 and a waiver will need to be filled out. Talk to Lani for a copy of the waiver or fill it out online at <https://zerogravity.pfestore.com/waiver/WaiverInfo.aspx>

Dec. 14 Christmas Pageant rehearsal: Starts at 6:00pm in Sunday School rooms.
Orchestra Rehearsal: 7pm with Jenny Ammerman. Bring a music stand if you have one.

Dec. 18 Orchestra Rehearsal: 3pm with Jenny Ammerman. Bring a music stand if you have one.
Christmas Pageant: Starts at 4:00pm
No evening Confirmation classes

Dec. 25 Christmas Day: One service at 10:00 am
No evening Confirmation classes

Jan. 1 New Years Day: One service at 10:00 am
No evening Confirmation classes

Jan. 8 Youth night: Duct Tape Night in the Youth Room! For grades 6th-12th from 6-7:30pm we will participate in many different fun and entertaining team building games that all involve the use of Duct tape. There is no cost for this event.

Jan. 15 No evening Confirmation classes – MLK Jr. Weekend

Youth Night: Ropes course at MOA



Youth Night: Nerf Wars!



Children's Ministries

Happy Advent from Minnehaha Children's Ministries

November 27th marks the first Sunday of Advent. This season is the first of the church calendar, and will last through Christmas Eve. This is a season when we recognize the literal and figurative darkness in the world. This is a season when we embrace the hope for joy, peace, and love to be our reality. This is a season when we focus on bringing light to our world. This year, our Advent theme is "Seeing the Word." We're going to be looking for ways to make all these abstract ideas as tangible and understandable as possible. Each week we'll be looking at images that help us to better understand God's word.

For children, and really, all of us, illustrations are invaluable for helping us understand the story. Equally effective for understanding is acting in a way that brings to life these ideas. So, this Advent we challenge you to find actions that bring others hope, peace, joy, and love. We challenge you to work together as a family to find ways to bring light to the darkness. On November 27th, in between services, we'll be making Advent wreaths to help serve as a reminder. There are countless ideas out there for families - please let me know if you'd like help finding them!

At Minnehaha, one of the exciting things about Advent is our preparation for the **Christmas Pageant**. Preparations have begun, and will continue in earnest through the next few weeks. Please have your child(ren) and youth at Sunday School as regularly as possible so they can be preparing their parts.

On **Wednesday, 14th December** we will have a **run-through** of the pageant:

- Join us for **dinner first at 5:30pm**, and then the run-through will **begin at 6pm**, and our goal will be to have everyone done by 6:45.
- The **pageant is on Sunday, 18th December at 4pm**, and will be followed by an all-church dinner.

If you will be around to worship with us for **Christmas Eve**, we have two services, at **4pm and 10pm**.

And, finally - it's not too early to begin planning for 2017:

- On **Saturday, 7th January: Children's Council is hosting a Child Care Night and Parents' Night Out**. Child care will be provided at the church from 5-8pm; and parents are invited to join together for dinner. Details will follow soon - but please mark your calendars and plan on joining us!
- The **Winter Retreat will be from Friday, 27th January - Sunday, 29th January** at Lake Koronis Assembly Grounds in Paynesville. This year's theme is "Moving From Isolation to Community." Registration forms are available in the narthex, or online at <https://www.jotform.com/Minnehaha/minnehaha-winter-retreat-2017>.

As always, please let me know if you have any questions or concerns.

May your Advent be filled with hope,

Jenia Strom
Director of Children & Family Ministries



Minnehaha Playgroup

For Children 5 and Under & their Caregivers

Thursdays, from 9-11am

Stop in to play, talk, explore, support, and learn together. Feel free to bring snacks (no peanuts, please) if your child will need them. No RSVP necessary. All are welcome.

hosted by

Minnehaha United Methodist Church

When weather permits, we gather at local parks for playgroup. Otherwise, we meet at Minnehaha UMC, in the Childcare Room. If you'd like to join us on any given week, and want to know where to find us: join the "Minnehaha Playgroup" Facebook Page for weekly updates.



Halloween Party Fun



Highlights from the November 15, 2016 Church Council Meeting

PASTOR'S 2017 COMPENSATION PACKAGE APPROVED: A Charge Conference was held at the start of the Council meeting to approve Becky's compensation package—salary, continuing education, travel and other professional expenses—for 2017. The amount is \$89,889.13, which was essentially unchanged from her 2016 compensation package. It was approved unanimously. (Rev. John Darlington, presiding church elder; Peggy Kirkpatrick, Staff-Parish Relations)

TREASURER'S REPORT: We remain on budget, with revenues and expenses in line with projections through October 31. The church remains current on its obligations to staff, vendors, contractors, apportionments and the inter-fund loan through October 31, 2016. (Sue Claude, Finance)

EVENT CLEAN-UP CHECKLIST PRESENTED: Our church building is busy every day of the week. Along with Sunday worship and our church committee meetings, small groups, choir, UMW, etc., etc., we have Mandala Montessori, Brighter Minds Music, 14 outside groups and more using the church. Plus special events like the Harvest Dinner and Halloween Carnival. As a result, it can be a challenge to keep the church picked up and clean at all times. Our custodian, Steve Meier, put together a helpful list of things that groups can do to keep the building looking good. We're asking all groups and committees that use the church to return rooms to their original condition, clean up any messes, close windows and turn off lights. There was also discussion about groups paying an additional fee for special events to help cover the cost of added custodial services. We will continue to pursue these and other ways to keep our church looking good. (Peggy Kirkpatrick, Staff-Parish Relations; Dean Ammerman, Council Chair)

QUESTION: WHAT ARE WE DOING TO BRING JUSTICE TO THE WORLD? Jenia Strom started a discussion about the church providing support for immigrant and refugee families in Minneapolis. An associate of hers asked if Minnehaha UMC would be interested in helping or "adopting" one of eight Somali families whose sons were just convicted of conspiracy to support a terrorist organization. We would provide help for the parents, the young men in prison, children and other dependents. St. Mary's Episcopal Church in St. Paul is currently supporting one family. It would involve helping to cover rent and education expenses; celebrating with the families at holidays and special events; providing furniture, food and transportation; and helping with fundraisers such as Somali cooking classes for the faith community. Interested? Contact Jenia Strom or Dean Ammerman. Thank you! (Dean Ammerman, Council Chair)

IMAGINE...INCREASING YOUR PLEDGE FOR 2017: A 10% increase in pledges would allow us to move forward with new initiatives, new programs and new ideas, and to catch up on some delayed maintenance. Imagine an even better Minnehaha UMC! Thank you for your time, talents and gifts. (Sue Claude, Finance Chair)

3 PARENTS' NIGHT OUT DATES: The church is planning Parents' Night Out dates for three Saturdays at the start of 2017: January 7, March 4 and May 6. The money raised will be used for scholarships for our summer church camps. (Jenia Strom, Children's Ministries; Beth Minehart, Welcoming)

QUESTION: SHOULD THE CHURCH OFFER FREE WIFI TO PEOPLE WHO USE OUR CHURCH? Initial response to the question is that it would be a good idea to have free WiFi in the church. Want to weigh in? Talk to your Church Council members and let them know your thoughts. (Dean Ammerman, Council Chair)

Continued from pg. 6

TOYS AND MORE FOR FOOD SHELF FAMILIES: You can help make sure every child and teen whose family uses our Food Shelf has a present this Christmas. Renee Beymer is collecting toys and other gifts that parents and guardians can select for their children on Tuesdays during the Food Shelf. Your generosity is appreciated. (Renee Beymer, Christmas Toy Champion)

SUPPORT THE MINNEHAHA FOOD SHELF: You can support the Food Shelf in a lot of different ways. Place a donation in the offering plate using the envelope in the pews. Plan to come to the annual Pasta Dinner on January 11 (the Accordion Band will be there!). Thanks for helping your neighbors in need. (Judy Durfey, Food Shelf Chair)

NEXT MEETING DECEMBER 13 AT 6:30 PM: The next Church Council meeting is scheduled for December 13 at 6:30 p.m. Everyone in the church is invited to attend. Complete minutes of the meeting are available on request.

—submitted by Dean Ammerman, Church Council Chair

Toy Drive

During the Tuesdays of December Food Self Parents are able to select toys for their children ranging from baby toys to dolls to hot wheels to table foosball to MP3 players and clock radios for older children. Each child received a toy, a stocking stuffer and a hat and or gloves if needed. We also had gift bags and wrapping paper. All this is made possible by the generosity of members of Minnehaha.

There are three ways to help with this mission one of the ways we serve.

Buy toys and bring them to church

Designate an offering for toys in the Sunday offering

Donate cash to be used for toys

With your help Good things will happen here

Haitian Art Sale

Dear MUMC friends,

Need an excuse to procrastinate on your Christmas shopping? The St. James Haiti Committee is privileged to host a Haitian art sale at Minnehaha at 10 a.m. (between the 9 and 11 a.m. services) on Sunday, Dec. 11. We'll be in the sanctuary selling artwork we've brought back after visits to our partner parish, Bonne Nouvelle, in the mountain village of Bigonet.

The artwork includes intricate metal wall sculptures made from recycled oil drums: They're lovely, affordable (similar sculptures are sold in boutiques and in catalogs like Serry for significantly more), and they make beautiful gifts. All proceeds will help support the local community, particularly the village's K-10 school. It's the only school in the area, and it's open to all children – regardless of their parents' ability to pay tuition. (The Haitian government provides no support for rural schools.)

St. James shares a nine-year-old partnership with Bonne Nouvelle that's rooted in mutuality and a shared commitment to cross-cultural learning. That includes jointly supporting the school, as well as the children and families who are part of it. Given that Hurricane Matthew has taken everything from our friends – their crops, their sustenance, their livelihoods – this partnership is more important than ever.

Since the earthquake of 2010, which leveled their village, our partners have worked enormously hard to rebuild. We've been awed by their resilience, creativity, and spirit. Now they're once again faced with loss and devastation, but we are standing with them: helping provide lunches for schoolchildren; supporting the distribution of rice, cooking oil, and other staples to families; helping purchase nut- and fruit-tree seedlings for families; and supporting the long-term functioning of Bonne Nouvelle School, particularly teachers' pay.

You can join us in solidarity with our Haitian brothers and sisters – simply by purchasing a lovely work of art.

Even if your holiday shopping is finished, please stop by our table and chat – we'd love to talk to you about the partnership and the ways our Haitian friends continue to inspire us. Thanks, and hope to see you on the 11th!

Peace,

Susan Maas, on behalf of the St. James Haiti Committee

Annual Meeting

Our Annual Meeting (otherwise known as a Church Conference) will be held on Sunday, January 2, 2017 at 1:00 in the afternoon at the church. We're contemplating a football sort of theme, maybe even an opportunity to create your own fantasy team. We'll also approve the real slate of officers for the new year and pass our 2017 budget. You can wear a football jersey if you want, but only nerf footballs, please. ☺

Monthly Communion at Nokomis Square

On the second Thursday of the month at 1:00 p.m., Becky offers a brief communion service at Nokomis Square preceded by a conversation/study on some topic of interest. Anyone is welcome to come. This month we will be gathering on December 8.

Feeling a Little Blue for Christmas

Sure, there's lots to be joyful about as we approach Christmas, but the shorter days and colder temperatures don't leave everyone full of good cheer. Add in a feeling of frenzy from the rush of the season, and it already begins to feel a little overwhelming. Add in even more, a job loss or change, the loss of a loved one, a change in health, a strained friendship, a move, and it can begin to feel like we are out of sync with the joy being expressed at every turn.

You are invited to rest awhile in silence, in quiet music, and in the glow of candlelight as we observe our Blue Christmas Taizé service on December 9 at 7:00 p.m. Whether you need an opportunity to just sit still for a little bit, or you are looking for a way to acknowledge feelings of loss or depression, join with others for an hour of reflection and rest as we continue to find God's presence in the midst of wherever we are.

Christmas Eve

Please join us, and invite your friends and neighbors, for Christmas Eve services this year. We'll have a more child-oriented service (which adults are welcome to attend as well J) at 4:00 p.m. featuring music with The Methodicals and a more traditional candlelight service with choir and organ at 10:00 p.m.

United Methodist Women

- Anyone who like to bake Christmas cookies is welcome to come to the annual Cookie Exchange on Sat., Dec. 3 in our kitchen. You can bring 10 dozen cookies to trade or the ingredients to make the cookies there or the dough to bake in our wonderful convection oven. The "exchange" part will be around noon. Some cookies will be left for our shut-ins.
- Pick up a package of cookies for our church members who have a hard time getting to church; they will be in the Fellowship Hall on Sunday, Dec. 4 and hopefully you can deliver them with a note of cheer.
- Come to the annual Christmas luncheon for the UMW on Wed., Dec. 14 in the Fellowship Hall at 11:30. We will begin by packing cookies, continue on to a lovely soup lunch and a listening to the premiere performance of "Bethlehem C.S. I." by our fabled sit-down players. You are welcome to bring gifts for Simpson Shelter which will be delivered the following Friday.
- Watch for announcements of our All Church Play which will be performed the last weekend in February. Rehearsals will begin the third week in January. All ages and sexes are invited to perform!



UMW Fall Bazaar



Registration

Name(s) and age(s) of those attending: _____

Address: _____

Phone Number: _____

Email: _____

Dietary Restrictions: _____

Carpools will be arranged.

- ☐ I am able and willing to drive, I have room for _____
- ☐ I need a ride to the retreat.

Pricing information is listed on the backside of this form. Please complete it and submit to the office.

Alternately, you can register online at:

<https://form.jotform.com/Minnehaha-minnehaha-winter-retreat-2017>

What will we do there?

Outdoor Activities

Broomball

Ice Skating

Cross country ski trails

Bonfire

Gym Activities

Basketball

Volleyball

Ping Pong

Carpet Ball

Air Hockey

Social Activities

Cards

Jigsaw Puzzles

Singing

Joking

Hanging Out

Skit Night

Learning Activities

Programming for adults, youth, and children

Worship on Sunday morning

No cooking; no washing dishes, no housework.

Personal hygiene is optional.

Still have questions?

Talk to Paul Minehart, Joe Schlosser, David Graham, Jenia Strom, Leilani Thompson, or Becky Sechrist.

Join us for ...



Minnehaha's Winter Retreat



Jan. 27th-29th, 2017
at Lake Koronis
Assembly Grounds



Moving From Isolation to Community

Each year, people from Minnehaha UMC travel north to Lake Koronis Assembly Grounds in Paynesville, MN. For the weekend, we leave our busy schedules behind and gather together for fellowship, for relaxation, and for learning and worship.

This year, we will explore what it takes for individuals and groups to move from isolation to community. Looking at the Biblical depiction of immigration – what it means to be an immigrant and what it means to welcome people into community – and reflecting on our own experiences of being in both isolation and in community, we'll consider

what we can do as a community to truly open our hearts and doors.

We hope you will consider joining us for this wonderful weekend!

Your registration fee gives you:

- 2 nights lodging
- 5 meals (breakfast, lunch, and dinner on Saturday, and breakfast and lunch on Sunday)
- 3 hours of childcare
- 24/7 intergenerational opportunities

Lots of playmates for everyone!

2017 Winter Retreat Pricing

1 Adult Lakeview	\$125
2 Adults Lakeview	\$250
1 Adult Sunrise	\$190
2 Adults Sunrise	\$300
Youth (11-18)	\$95
Children (4-11)	\$80
Infant/Toddler (0-3)	Free

Please look to the left to see what your registration pays for. No refunds for people who leave early and/or eat less than 5 meals. The amount paid by partial attendees not used to cover the cost of this weekend will go into the camp scholarship fund. Families in need are encouraged to ask for a scholarship (please speak with Jenia Strom, Becky Sechrist, or Leilani Thompson).

Total Amount Due: _____
Total Amount Paid: _____



Return registration form and check by January 15th to
Minnehaha United Methodist

3701 East 50th Street
Minneapolis, MN 55417
Phone: 612/721-6231
www.minnehaha.org



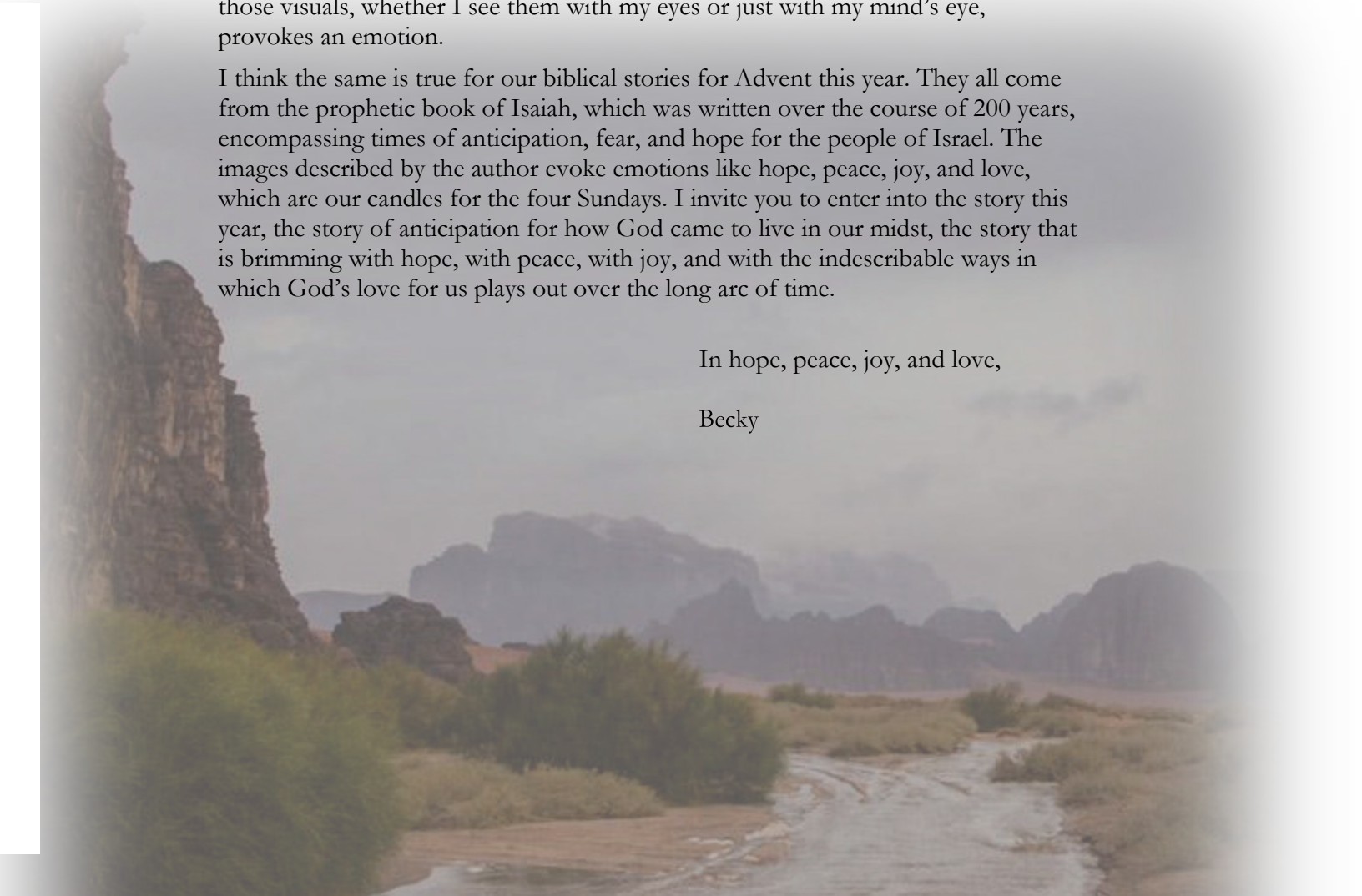
Seeing

Brown Christmases happen in the Twin Cities 28% of the time. I have to admit, I'm one of those people whose time of Advent, of preparation, is rooted in what I see around me. As I write, my geranium on my back patio is still blooming. It's hard to think about digging out my Advent wreath and setting it out while my garden is still blooming. Thankfully, snow is predicted very soon, so by Thanksgiving I'm hoping that my world will have turned cold and snowy enough to prompt me to go down into my basement and dig it out. I think I'm not alone in being prompted by the visuals in my world. Green grass and flowers prompt in me a different thing than red and yellow leaves and white caps on the lake. Snow mounded up around the corners of our roads brings a kind of joy all its own, as does sitting at the edge of a calm lake watching the sun set over the edge of the water. I watch for the dark-eyed juncos to reappear in my back yard each late fall with the same enthusiasm that I note the return of yellow to the goldfinches at my feeder in the spring. I don't always rely on my eyesight, however, regularly painting pictures in my head of what an encounter with a faraway friend might be like, or imagining what the church might be like in the future. Each of those visuals, whether I see them with my eyes or just with my mind's eye, provokes an emotion.

I think the same is true for our biblical stories for Advent this year. They all come from the prophetic book of Isaiah, which was written over the course of 200 years, encompassing times of anticipation, fear, and hope for the people of Israel. The images described by the author evoke emotions like hope, peace, joy, and love, which are our candles for the four Sundays. I invite you to enter into the story this year, the story of anticipation for how God came to live in our midst, the story that is brimming with hope, with peace, with joy, and with the indescribable ways in which God's love for us plays out over the long arc of time.

In hope, peace, joy, and love,

Becky





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12/16

